

The biggest thing that derails people's progress toward change is unexpected obstacles. We wish we could do something about that for you, but we can't. We do know that having an emergency fund and other savings accounts can make these obstacles a lot easier to deal with, but we can't take them away entirely. All we can do is give you the same encouragement we give ourselves: "Focus on the things that are in your control and learn to expect the unexpected."

We're not saying to expect bad things to happen, but know that your journey will constantly alternate between smooth seasons and seasons of friction. All we can do is curate the environment that we have control over in hopes of minimizing as many self-imposed obstacles as possible. Part 3 is dedicated to talking about curating your external environment, relationships, and mindset in a way that will support your new spending skills and habits.

Curating our internal and external environments is like wearing a coat on a walk in the fall. You could definitely take a walk without one, but it probably wouldn't be as long or as enjoyable as if you were wearing one. And every gust of wind would feel much more like a personal attack. By now you know and understand values-based spending, but without any support you probably won't practice it very long, and that first unexpected obstacle is definitely going to feel like a sign to quit. When you focus on environment, you stand a much better chance of making these changes last. And the easiest place to start is your external environment.

This includes the ways you refine the world around you to support your values-based decisions. Should you add more self-care routines into your schedule or reduce the number of weekly commitments you have? Should you get more organizational bins to manage what's in your closet or give away what you don't use anymore? To figure out how most people would answer these questions, a group of researchers at University of Virginia conducted a study¹ to find out how people tend to solve problems that require creative thinking. Do we err on the side of adding or taking away? After a series of experiments with over a thousand participants, they found that no matter the problem at hand or the incentives provided, people tend to default to adding things to solve their problems. No more than 40 percent of participants on any experiment ever chose to subtract or simplify to solve it, even on problems where the subtractive option was the only right solution. The study showed that our brains err on the side of more when